

# Reflective Teaching Statement

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Review period: Spring 2026 and Fall 2026

|                               |          |                  |                          |
|-------------------------------|----------|------------------|--------------------------|
| 4                             | 125      | 3                | 2                        |
| Sections in the review period | Students | New preparations | 16-to-8-week conversions |

Across this review period I taught the department's required undergraduate managerial economics course to a large asynchronous section, and its graduate time-series econometrics course to a small evening seminar. This fall I am teaching two accelerated eight-week sections, one of which — graduate mathematical economics — I am teaching for the first time. Three of these four preparations did not exist in a form I could teach before I built them.

The through-line is that I want students to be able to *do* something at the end, not to recognize a term. That commitment shows up as a design choice in every course, and it is also where the courses are hardest and where they have most clearly failed.

## ECON 301: making the assessment match the claim

Managerial economics is required for the major, and the students who take it asynchronously are mostly seniors, working: of the sixteen who responded to the opinion survey, thirteen held a job and every one of them was taking the course because the major required it. A course like that can very easily become a semester of multiple-choice practice in a publisher platform. So I made the midterm two full case studies rather than a timed exam, and built the weekly rhythm around application-based activities in Connect that put a concept into a decision before the quiz asks about it.

The class did well: a median final score of 90.2%, no grade below C-, and 98% of students clearing 70% on the comprehensive final. The survey item I care about most — whether the course required critical thinking — came back at 4.44 out of 5, and one student volunteered that “the midterm being two case studies was fantastic, and something that I wish more classes would copy.”

But the case studies are also where the class did worst. On Case Study 1, 78% of students reached the 70% threshold my own syllabus sets as the standard for the communication outcome; on Case Study 2, only 67% did — below the standard. The instrument I trust most is the one my students met least well. I read that as a scaffolding problem rather than an ability problem: the case studies arrive with a rubric but without a graded intermediate step, so a student who is going to misread the assignment does not find out until it is graded. In

the eight-week fall section I have moved to a single assigned case study with the rubric applied to a required outline first.

### **ECON 707/807: a project, staged**

Econometrics II is built around a semester-long forecasting project in three parts — a pitch, a data-and-model report, and a final forecast with an evaluation report written for a non-specialist. The point of splitting it is that forecasting is a sequence of judgment calls, and a student who only submits at the end never has to defend a choice while it is still changeable.

All three MA program outcomes cleared the 80% threshold, at 100%, 87.5% and 87.5%. I do not think that is the interesting result. Seven of eight students scored above 90% on every measure, which tells me the point allocations are not discriminating between competent and excellent work. And the one student who fell short did so on *both* project-based outcomes while meeting the exam standard — a missing data report and a weak final memo. The failure mode was disengagement from a multi-stage assignment, not an inability to specify a model. Staging the project earlier in the eight-week version means a stall at the data stage is visible while there is still time to intervene.

### **ECON 625: designing for a section of three**

Mathematical economics runs this fall with three students, which is not a footnote but a design constraint. A section that small has no anonymity: drop-in office hours are effectively individual tutorials, and any outcome measure moves by a third if one student disengages. So the course puts its weight on frequent graded work rather than on two high-stakes sittings — five problem sets, one per module, all five counted with no dropped score, because each set covers material that appears nowhere else and both exams are cumulative. An ungraded self-check diagnostic sits in the orientation module, posted before the add/drop deadline, so a student can judge the prerequisite fit for themselves rather than discovering it in week four of an eight-week term.

### **What did not work**

- **An exam it was rational to skip.** ECON 707/807 drops the lowest of three exams, and five of the eight students recorded a non-attempt on Exam 3 — correctly, given the policy. An assessment most students can skip without cost is not an assessment. The eight-week version drops to two exams, both counted.
- **Publisher-platform friction I did not catch fast enough.** ECON 301 students reported that McGraw-Hill Connect links on the Canvas dashboard resolved to unpublished modules, and that some Connect assignments did not line up with the chapter under discussion. That is exactly the kind of problem an asynchronous student cannot route around, and I should have been auditing the links weekly rather than at module open.

- **A pacing complaint I take seriously.** “Less material to review each week because it was a little overwhelming,” from a sixteen-week section, is a warning worth carrying into two eight-week sections. The fall ECON 301 schedule reserves an entire week for the case study midterm with no competing activity or homework, and the ECON 625 syllabus tells students the weekly hour cost before the add/drop deadline rather than after it.

### **Where this is going**

The next cycle has three concrete pieces of work. Convert the ECON 707 project checklists into weighted rubrics so the assessment can distinguish good from excellent. Get item-level data out of Canvas for the ECON 301 outcome measures, which are written against ten specific final-exam questions I currently cannot isolate from a total score. And finish the eight-week ECON 707/807 build, whose public course site is already standing at [r3xstar.github.io/econ707](https://r3xstar.github.io/econ707).

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Every figure in this statement is computed from the course records listed in the portfolio's evidence index. Rex W. Sitti, September 2026.